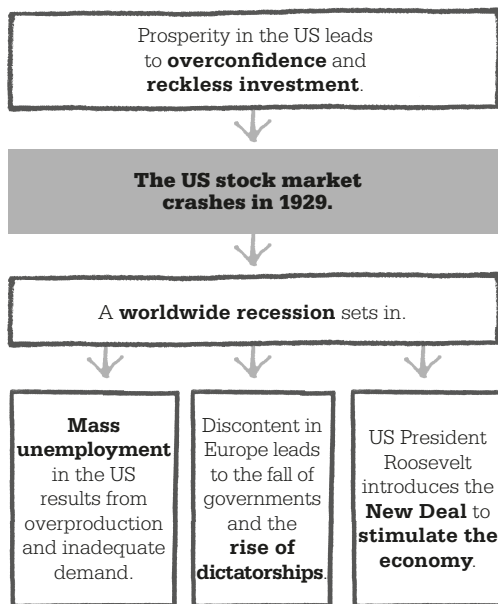




Franklin D Roosevelt

Franklin Delano Roosevelt (1882–1945) was the only president ever elected to serve four terms in office. He achieved this success despite suffering from polio in 1921, which crippled both legs and almost led him to give up on his political career.

Roosevelt won the election to be the governor of New York in 1929, and in 1932 was nominated as Democratic candidate for the presidency. Pledging a New Deal for the American people, he won a landslide victory. In his first 100 days, he introduced a program of social and economic reform to combat the Great Depression. These immensely popular measures won him a second landslide victory in 1936.

In 1941, the US was propelled into World War II, and Roosevelt took his place as one of the allied war leaders. He was one of the principal movers in the plans for a United Nations but died in March 1945, just before the UN's first meeting was convened in San Francisco.

The Great Depression

In the US, factories were closed and workers fired. In the spring of 1933, the agricultural sector was on the verge of disaster: 25 percent of farmers were without work, and many even lost their farms. Unemployment went from 1.5 million in 1929 to 12.8 million, or 24.75 percent of the workforce, by 1933, a pattern seen around the world.

Unemployment in Britain rose to 2.5 million, 25 percent of the workforce, with heavy industry, such as shipbuilding, particularly badly hit. Germany suffered greatly, since its post-war economy was supported by huge American loans which it was unable to pay back.

A New Deal

The crash helped bring Democrat Franklin D. Roosevelt into the White House in 1932. His policy, the New Deal, introduced a program of social welfare for the poor and government expenditure on huge public projects that created new jobs.

The Great Depression marked the end of the United States' post-war boom. In Europe, many turned to right-wing parties, such as Adolf Hitler's National Socialist Party in Germany, with its promise to restore the economy. In many countries, recovery came only with the increase in employment brought about by World War II. ■